

RUTH

First draft

The book of Ruth · Treatment v4 · Beat sheet v1

Series working title: Adonai

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PROLOGUE: THE HOUSE OF BREAD

FADE IN:

EXT. THRESHING FLOOR — RIDGE EAST OF BETHLEHEM — DAWN

A circle of packed earth on the ridge, worn smooth by generations of oxen. This time of year it should be heaped with grain.

It's bare.

The wind comes up off the desert, hot and dry. It lifts a skin of dust and old chaff off the floor, carries it a little way, and lets it fall.

EXT. BOAZ'S TERRACES — DAWN

Stone terraces step down the hillside below the town. The barley on them stands stunted and white in cracked ground.

BOAZ (33) walks the rows: a landowner's clothes, a laborer's hands. He snaps off a head of barley, rubs it between his palms, and blows.

Husk. Nothing else.

He looks at his empty palm for a long moment.

BOAZ'S WIFE (about 30) comes down the terrace steps with a water jar on her hip.

She holds it out. He drinks one mouthful and hands it back. She drinks one mouthful, and stoppers it.

That's the whole conversation.

EXT. BETHLEHEM — ELIMELECH'S COURTYARD — MORNING

A small stone house around a courtyard. A DONKEY stands being loaded, and not liking it.

ELIMELECH (40) cinches a strap. NAOMI (36) packs what's left of a household into baskets: a lamp, a grinding stone, folded cloth. When a hand reaches in to help, she slaps it away.

MAHLON (17), thin, ties down a rope. He coughs and swallows it.

CHILION (15) lifts the lid of the bread bin. Peers in. Holds the pose. A long, theatrical moment.

CHILION
(announcing it to the
courtyard)
House of bread.

MAHLON
 (not looking up from the
 rope)
 Every day. You say it every single
 day.

CHILION
 Because every day it's still true.

MAHLON
 It wasn't funny the first time.
 He coughs, which spoils it. Chilion grins.

ELIMELECH
 Enough. Both of you.
 (beat)
 Mahlon, the rope. Chilion, it's
 empty. Stop opening it.

Chilion drops the lid. Naomi flicks him with a cloth on
 her way past, all business.

Then her back is to them, and she's laughing.

EXT. BETHLEHEM — STREET — MORNING

The donkey goes up the street with the family behind it.
 NEIGHBORS watch from doorways: some sorry, some not. One
 man shakes his head and goes inside.

At the corner, NAOMI'S FRIEND (about 36) steps out and
 catches Naomi's arm. She presses a twist of dried figs
 into Naomi's hands.

Naomi looks down at them. In this year, figs are a
 fortune.

NAOMI'S FRIEND
 Moab, Naomi?

NAOMI
 There's bread in Moab.

NAOMI'S FRIEND
 There's Chemosh in Moab.

NAOMI
 Then Chemosh can feed us until it
 rains here.

They hold each other a moment too long.

NAOMI'S FRIEND
 Come back.

Naomi doesn't promise. She goes.

EXT. BETHLEHEM — THE GATE — MORNING

The town gate: a passage through the wall, with stone benches along it in the shade. Two ELDERS sit there. One of them is THE OLD ELDER (70s), thin as a stick.

Elimelech stands before them with THE NEIGHBOR (50s), a careful man. Scraps of silver go onto a hand balance and are weighed.

NAOMI

That field's worth five times that.

The neighbor lets out a single small chuckle.

THE NEIGHBOR

Right now...

His hand waves at everything around them: the dust, the dead terraces beyond the gate, the empty benches.

THE NEIGHBOR (CONT'D)

...a field's worth what somebody will pay.

Elimelech takes the silver.

THE OLD ELDER

(a voice like a dry branch)

Witness it. The use of Elimelech's field goes to this man. When Elimelech's family can, they buy it back. Or a kinsman buys it back for them.

ELIMELECH

When we come back.

The old elder looks at him, and says nothing.

EXT. ROAD EAST OF BETHLEHEM — BELOW BOAZ'S TERRACES — LATER

The family on the road east, past the dead terraces.

Boaz comes down to meet them with a sack half full on his shoulder: last year's barley, from his own store. His wife walks behind him.

BOAZ

God be with you, Elimelech.

Elimelech looks at the sack and shakes his head. He knows how little is left in Boaz's storeroom.

Boaz holds it out anyway. Naomi takes it.

NAOMI
Thank you, Boaz.

The two men stand there a moment: the one who's staying,
and the one who's going.

ELIMELECH
You think I'm wrong.

BOAZ
I think you have two sons.

Chilion eyes the sack.

CHILION
Is that barley?

Mahlon elbows him.

EXT. RIDGE EAST OF BETHLEHEM — CONTINUOUS

The land falls away east into desert: bare hills, then the
great trench of the Salt Sea, and beyond it, standing
blue, the mountains of Moab, with a grey veil of rain
hanging over them.

Naomi looks back once at Bethlehem.

Then the four of them walk toward the rain until they're
too small to see.

FADE TO BLACK.

ACT ONE: FULL AND EMPTY

FADE IN:

EXT. MOABITE VILLAGE — THRESHING FLOOR — DAY

Green. It has rained here. Barley stands thick on the
slopes around a cluster of flat-roofed houses.

On the village floor, oxen drag a threshing sledge in slow
circles over cut grain. MEN work the heap with forks.

Up the road comes Elimelech's family: four dusty strangers
and a donkey.

The men stop working, one by one.

MOABITE MAN
(loud enough to carry)
Israelites.

Another man spits.

An OLD MOABITE sitting at the edge of the floor doesn't get up.

OLD MOABITE

Their grandfathers came over the river and stabbed our king in his own upstairs room, and locked the door on him.

OLD MOABITE (CONT'D)

Then they held the fords and cut down ten thousand of ours.

Mahlon steps forward.

Without looking at him, Elimelech puts a hand flat on his son's chest, and keeps it there.

ELIMELECH

None of us were there.
(beat)
We've come to work.

RUTH'S FATHER (40s), broad and sunburned, the man who owns the floor, looks the four of them over: the donkey's thin load, the boys' arms, the cough.

RUTH'S FATHER

You work my fields, you take half a share of what you cut.

RUTH'S FATHER (CONT'D)

There's a house at the edge of the village. Some of it still has a roof.

NAOMI

Half a share? We had our own—

ELIMELECH

Yes.

Naomi looks at him. He doesn't look back.

Ruth's father nods. He isn't cruel. He's a man who knows a bargain when one walks up his road.

RUTH'S FATHER

(over his shoulder)
Ruth! Orpah! Water for the men.

At the edge of the floor, two girls with water jars have been watching the whole thing: RUTH (14) and her cousin ORPAH (14), who lives in the same house.

They come with the water. Orpah looks the Israelite boys over on the way.

ORPAH

(low, to Ruth)

The tall one's handsome. If somebody
fed him.

Ruth isn't looking at the boys. She's watching their
parents: Elimelech's hand, still flat on his son's chest.
Naomi's face.

INT. RUTH'S FATHER'S HOUSE — EVENING

One room, a hearth, a ladder to the sleeping loft. In a
niche in the wall stands a small STONE FIGURE OF CHEMOSH.

RUTH'S MOTHER (38) pours a thread of oil before it and
speaks to it plainly, the way you'd speak to an elder you
trust.

RUTH'S MOTHER

Keep the rain coming. Keep the fever
away from the children. And keep the
Israelites honest.

Supper on the floor: bread, lentils. Ruth's father, Ruth's
mother, RUTH'S BROTHER (17), Orpah, Ruth.

RUTH'S BROTHER

You've let Israelites onto our land.

RUTH'S FATHER

I've let cheap hands onto our land.

RUTH'S MOTHER

They won't sacrifice to Chemosh.
Their god doesn't even have a face.

RUTH

Then how do they pray to him?

RUTH'S MOTHER

Badly. Look how hungry they are.

Everyone laughs, except Ruth.

INT. THE RUIN — NIGHT

The half-collapsed house at the edge of the village, a
week later. New beams lie across it now, with branches and
packed mud over them. Fresh plaster on the walls, with the
prints of boys' hands still in it.

The boys asleep. Elimelech lies awake. Naomi beside him,
awake too.

NAOMI

Half a share. In Bethlehem you'd
have laughed at him.

ELIMELECH

In Bethlehem there's nothing to have
half of.

She has no answer to that.

ELIMELECH (CONT'D)

Two harvests. We put away what we
can, we go home, and we buy the
field back.

NAOMI

Two.

ELIMELECH

Two.

He says it like a man holding a door shut.

EXT. MOABITE VILLAGE — THRESHING FLOOR — DAY

The floor is heaped with grain.

Ruth's father measures out the Israelites' share himself,
with a wooden measure, into Elimelech's sack. Scoop.
Shake. Pour. Scoop.

Elimelech watches it go in. Something in his face goes
still.

Each measure is shaken down and leveled short of the rim.

Mahlon sees his father see it.

The men on the floor go quiet. They want to know what the
foreigner will do.

Elimelech takes the scoop out of Ruth's father's hand. He
fills the measure to the brim, levels it with the flat of
his hand, and holds it out.

ELIMELECH

A full measure. That was the
bargain.

Ruth's father looks at the measure. At his men, watching.
At a stranger with nothing, who isn't going to back down.

Then he laughs, once.

RUTH'S FATHER

Israelites.

He lets it stand. He pours the full measure into the sack
himself.

At the edge of the floor, Ruth has watched the whole thing. She has never seen anyone face her father down.

EXT. THE RUIN — BEHIND THE HOUSE — LATER

Elimelech, alone. His hands are shaking.

Naomi comes around the corner. She takes his hands in hers. Neither of them says anything.

EXT. MOABITE VILLAGE — LANE BELOW THE ROOFTOPS — DAY

Wailing from the rooftops. ORPAH'S GRANDFATHER is dead, and the village mourns him the way Moab mourns: heads shaved, beards cut off, and blades drawn across forearms.

Ruth stands beside Orpah at the bier. There's a fresh cut on her own arm.

At the edge of the crowd, the Israelite family watches. The boys have never seen anything like it.

CHILION
(whispering)
Why are they cutting themselves?

NAOMI
It's how they grieve here.

MAHLON
Should we—

NAOMI
No. We don't cut ourselves for the dead. We belong to the Lord.

Later, as the crowd breaks up, Ruth passes Mahlon in the lane. He can't stop looking at her arm.

MAHLON
Doesn't that hurt?

RUTH
It's supposed to.

She walks on.

EXT. RUTH'S FATHER'S FIELD — DAY

Grey sky. The first rains have turned the earth dark. Elimelech walks behind an ox and a wooden plow. He's sweating, and it's cold.

At the next furrow, Mahlon stops.

MAHLON
You're sweating.

ELIMELECH

I'm working.

He keeps plowing.

EXT. EDGE OF THE VILLAGE — A NEW GRAVE — DAY

Wet earth heaped over a fresh grave. Naomi, Mahlon, Chilion.

Nobody else.

Naomi tears the neck of her dress and sits down in the dirt.

Chilion tries to say something light. It's what he does.

CHILION

At least he doesn't have to—

He can't finish it. Mahlon puts an arm around him and holds on.

EXT. EDGE OF THE VILLAGE — THE GRAVE — LATER

The boys have gone in. Naomi sits by the grave alone.

NAOMI

You said two.

EXT. EDGE OF THE VILLAGE — THE GRAVE — DUSK

Footsteps on the path. Naomi looks up.

Ruth, with a loaf wrapped in a cloth. She sets it down beside Naomi without a word, and sits down in the dirt next to her.

EXT. THE RUIN — COURTYARD — NIGHT

Naomi on her knees in the courtyard, praying under her breath. There's nothing in front of her: no figure, no niche. Just the wall, and the dark.

Ruth, on her way home, stops at the gate and watches.

RUTH

Who are you talking to?

NAOMI

God.

Ruth looks around the empty courtyard.

RUTH

Where is he?

Naomi takes a long time to answer.

NAOMI
Everywhere, they say.

Her hand sweeps out across the ground and up toward the sky, taking in all of it.

A breath. She's holding back tears.

NAOMI (CONT'D)
But tonight I couldn't tell you.

Ruth doesn't go. She stays at the gate.

INT. RUTH'S FATHER'S HOUSE — DAY

Naomi sits across from Ruth's father, the head of a household now. MAHLON (19) and CHILION (17) stand behind her, broad from three harvests of other men's fields.

Up through the hatch to the roof, out of sight, RUTH (16) and ORPAH (16) lie flat on their stomachs, listening.

RUTH'S FATHER
Your sons have nothing.

NAOMI
My sons have worked your fields for three harvests at half what they're worth. You know what they're worth. You've been counting it.

RUTH'S FATHER
And your god? Who will my girls pray to?

NAOMI
Whoever they like. Same as now.

RUTH'S FATHER
Thirty shekels' weight of silver. Each.

Naomi laughs at him.

NAOMI
For a princess, maybe. In Egypt.

On the roof, Orpah has to put her hand over her mouth.

They settle somewhere in between. Both of them leave the room thinking they've won.

On the roof, Orpah squeezes Ruth's hand.

EXT. MOABITE VILLAGE — THRESHING FLOOR — NIGHT

A double wedding: drums, torches, a feast spread on the threshing floor, Moabite songs. Mahlon beside Ruth. Chilion beside Orpah.

And in the middle of the dancing, Naomi dances.

FADE TO BLACK.

FADE IN:

SUPER: Ten years later.

INT. MAHLON AND RUTH'S HOUSE — NIGHT

Dark. MAHLON (29) coughs in his sleep: the long winter cough he's had every winter for ten years.

RUTH (26) kneels before a niche in the wall. In it stands a clay goddess, a household figure as long as a hand, the kind every house in the village has.

Ruth prays without a sound, lips moving, both hands pressed flat to her belly. For a child. With her whole heart.

In the doorway, NAOMI (46) watches. She doesn't interrupt. After a while she goes back to her own bed.

INT. MAHLON AND RUTH'S HOUSE — MORNING

The bread oven in the courtyard. Ruth and Naomi bake together the way people do after ten years: without talking, each handing the other the next thing before she asks for it.

Ruth sings under her breath: a Bethlehem harvest song Naomi taught her long ago.

RUTH
(singing, under her
breath)
A month for the barley, a month for
the wheat, a month for the
threshing...

NAOMI
(not looking up)
Measuring.

Ruth stops. Naomi sings the line properly, without looking up.

NAOMI (CONT'D)
(singing)
...a month for the harvest and
measuring...

Through the wall from next door: CHILION and ORPAH,
arguing, loudly. Then laughing, louder.

Ruth and Naomi look at each other. Ruth smiles.

INT. MAHLON AND RUTH'S HOUSE - DAY

Mahlon in bed, sweating, eyes open. Ruth wringing out a
cloth.

Through the wall: a woman's cry. Orpah's. It doesn't stop.

Naomi is on her feet and out the door.

Mahlon heard it too. Ruth puts the cloth on his forehead,
and her hand stays there.

INT. MAHLON AND RUTH'S HOUSE - DAY

Mahlon, grey, propped against the wall. Ruth holds a cup
to his mouth, because he can't hold it himself. Some of
the water runs into his beard. She wipes it away with her
thumb.

He's looking at the wall. The one Chilion and Orpah used
to argue through.

It's quiet now.

MAHLON
He'd have a joke for this.

RUTH
It wouldn't be funny.

He almost laughs. It turns into the cough, and the cough
takes a long time. She holds him through it.

INT. MAHLON AND RUTH'S HOUSE - NIGHT

One lamp. Naomi sits up with Mahlon, a wet cloth in her
hand. Ruth has fallen asleep sitting against the wall.

Naomi hums under her breath. A slow, plain tune: the one
she sang to both her boys when they were small.

Nobody hears it but him.

EXT. EDGE OF THE VILLAGE — THREE GRAVES — DAY

Two new graves beside Elimelech's. This time the whole village has come.

Wailing from the rooftops. RUTH'S MOTHER (50) draws a blade across her own forearm, then takes Ruth's arm. Ruth lets her.

Beside them, Orpah cuts her own arms for Chilion.

Naomi tears her clothes and sits in the dust between the three graves.

LATER. The crowd thins. Naomi takes Ruth's arm, tears a strip from the hem of her own ruined dress, and binds the cuts.

EXT. MOABITE MARKET — DAY

A market on the plateau: wool, salt, pots, a few sheep. Naomi with a basket, thinner, older than her years.

Behind her, a man is haggling in a Judean accent, Bethlehem's sounds in every word. She turns.

A TRADER (40s), with a donkey loaded with oil jars.

NAOMI
Where are you from?

TRADER
Judah. The hills by Bethlehem.

NAOMI
How is it there?

TRADER
The rain came back. God has visited his people.

He slaps the side of a jar.

TRADER (CONT'D)
There's bread in Bethlehem.

NAOMI
Do you know—

She stops. Whoever she was going to ask about, she doesn't. She isn't ready to hear who's dead.

She goes home, and starts to pack.

EXT. MOABITE VILLAGE — RUTH'S PARENTS' HOUSE — BEFORE DAWN

Grey light on the plateau. Wet grass. Somewhere a dog starts barking, thinks better of it, and stops.

Ruth stands in the doorway of her parents' house with a bundle on her back. Her forearms are bound in strips of dark cloth over cuts that haven't healed.

Ruth's mother sets her lamp on the step and goes straight for the strap of the bundle.

RUTH'S MOTHER
You never could tie a knot.

She unties it and ties it again, harder.

Inside the house, RUTH'S FATHER (50s) sits by the cold hearth with his back to the door.

RUTH'S MOTHER
When will you be back?

Ruth doesn't answer.

Her mother's hands stop on the strap. Then they finish the knot anyway.

RUTH'S MOTHER
Their god took your husband. He took everything that woman had. And you'll follow her to him?

RUTH
They're my family.

Her mother looks at her for a long moment. Then she goes inside, past the father, who doesn't move, and comes back with something closed in her fist.

Her own little clay goddess, the length of a thumb, worn smooth from a lifetime of handling.

She presses it into Ruth's hand and folds Ruth's fingers over it.

RUTH'S MOTHER
Then take her. Somebody should look after you.

Ruth looks past her mother, into the house.

RUTH
Father.

He doesn't turn. But his hand, resting on his knee, closes into a fist and stays that way.

Down the lane, two shapes wait in the half-dark with bundles on their backs: NAOMI (48) and ORPAH (26). Orpah lifts a hand.

Ruth kisses her mother, tucks the goddess into her sash, and goes.

Her mother stands in the doorway with the lamp and watches the three of them past the last house, the way Boaz once watched Elimelech's family go.

EXT. PLATEAU ROAD — MORNING

The plateau rolls west, green after the winter rains, with red poppies in the wild barley. Three women on the road, Naomi a few steps ahead.

Orpah walks backward in front of Ruth, talking. She's never been able to stand a silence.

ORPAH
Is it far?

NAOMI
Far enough.

ORPAH
Is there a well?

NAOMI
By the gate.

ORPAH
(to Ruth, delighted)
By the gate. We'll know everybody's
business in a week.

Ruth smiles. But she's watching Naomi.

ORPAH
Will they like us?

Naomi doesn't answer.

Ruth hears what that means. Orpah doesn't, or decides not to, and turns around to walk forward again.

Naomi's lips are moving. No sound. She's saying something to herself, over and over, the way you rehearse a thing you don't want to say.

Ruth sees it.

EXT. EDGE OF THE PLATEAU — CONTINUOUS

The road tops a last rise, and the world falls away.

Below them is the rift: a thousand meters of broken slope, then the Jordan, a green thread through brown country. To the south lies the Salt Sea, flat and pale. And across all of it, blue in the haze, the hills of Judah.

Naomi stops. The other two stop behind her.

For a while she just looks. Somewhere over there is Bethlehem.

She sets down her bundle and turns to them. She opens her mouth, and nothing comes.

Her face does it first. The arithmetic: three mouths, no field, no man, and a town that won't want two Moabite widows. Then the pain of it. Then a tiredness that goes all the way down. Then, slowly, something that settles.

NAOMI

Go back.

ORPAH

(a small, confused laugh)
What?

NAOMI

Both of you. Go home to your mothers.

Her voice cracks. She pushes through it.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

May God be as good to you as you've been to the dead. And to me.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

May he give each of you a husband you deserve.

She kisses Orpah. She kisses Ruth.

That's what breaks them. Orpah cries out loud, and then Ruth does.

ORPAH

No, no. We're coming with you.

RUTH

We're coming with you.

NAOMI

Go back, my daughters. Why would you come with me?

A laugh that isn't one. Her hand goes flat against her own stomach.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Am I going to have more sons for you
to marry?

Nobody laughs.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Go home. I'm too old for a husband.
And even if I said there was hope,
even if I had a husband tonight, and
had sons... would you wait for them
to grow up? Stay alone all those
years?

She shakes her head.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

No. This is far more bitter for me
than for you.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

(quieter)

The Lord's hand has turned against
me.

They cry again, all three of them.

Orpah wipes her face with both hands. She looks at Naomi
for a long time. Then she steps in and kisses her. Not a
protest this time. A goodbye.

ORPAH

(into Naomi's shoulder)

Mother.

Naomi holds her tight, then lets her go.

Ruth hasn't moved. Her hand has closed on Naomi's sleeve,
and it stays closed.

Orpah turns to her.

ORPAH

Ruth. Come with me.

Ruth shakes her head.

With her free hand she takes the clay goddess from her
sash and presses it into Orpah's palm.

RUTH

Give her back to my mother.

Orpah looks down at it, and understands. She takes Ruth's
face in both hands and rests her forehead against Ruth's.
Then she picks up her bundle and goes.

Down the road, alone, back toward the village, with the goddess in her fist. A little way off she turns and looks back.

Naomi watches her go: the bundle on her back, her people's village ahead of her, the goddess in her fist.

Then Naomi looks down at Ruth's hand on her sleeve. She puts her own hand over it, and gently, one finger at a time, starts to work it loose.

NAOMI

You know you should go back.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Go after her.

Ruth looks back down the road. Orpah, getting smaller. Past her, the smudge of smoke over the village. Her mother's house is in there somewhere.

Then the wind comes.

It comes up out of the desert behind them, out of the east, hot and dry. It flattens the grass toward the edge. It pulls Ruth's shawl forward and leans on her back like a hand, toward the land across the rift.

Ruth doesn't look up at the sky. For a moment she doesn't look at anything. Something in her face goes still.

She turns back to Naomi. Her hand is still on Naomi's sleeve. Naomi never got it loose.

RUTH

Don't ask me to leave you, or to turn back.

Naomi starts to answer...

RUTH (CONT'D)

Where you go, I'll go. Where you stay, I'll stay. Your people will be my people, and your God my God.

RUTH (CONT'D)

Where you die, I'll die, and that's where I'll be buried.

A beat. Then, steady, every word meant:

RUTH (CONT'D)

May Yahweh do that to me, and worse, if anything but death comes between us.

Naomi looks at her for a long time. We watch her take it in: the girl who brought bread to a grave nobody else came to, the girl at her oven for ten years, the girl who won't let go.

Then Naomi nods. Once. Small and direct, and accepting.

She says nothing more.

She bends for her bundle. Ruth gets there first, swings it up onto her shoulder beside her own, and Naomi lets her.

They start down.

EXT. EDGE OF THE PLATEAU — CONTINUOUS — WIDE

Two small figures going down into the rift.

Far behind them on the road east, a third figure has stopped to watch them go. After a while she turns and walks home.

EXT. JORDAN FORDS OPPOSITE JERICHO — DAY

The floor of the rift. Heat. Tamarisk and reeds. The river is high with spring: brown, fast, waist-deep at the ford.

They haven't spoken since the edge.

Ruth wades in first with both bundles on her head, feeling for the footing with her feet. On the far bank she sets them down, and comes back for Naomi.

Halfway across, Naomi slips. The current takes her legs out from under her.

Ruth's arm is around her before she goes under, and it holds.

They come up the far bank soaked and gasping, and sit down in the mud. Above them stands a long, ruined mound: Jericho, its walls a broken heap.

Naomi looks at Ruth's arm, still around her. She doesn't say anything.

She doesn't push it away, either.

EXT. ROAD INTO THE HILLS OF JUDAH — DAWN

The last morning. The road climbs through terraced hills. By the roadside stands a weathered pillar of stone, taller than a man.

Ruth doesn't know what it is. Naomi touches it as she passes, the way you'd touch a grandmother's hand.

EXT. BOAZ'S TERRACES — MORNING

The same terraces we saw dead in the prologue.

The barley stands gold, terrace after terrace, heavy and ripe. Nobody's cutting it yet.

Ruth can't know whose they are. We do.

EXT. BETHLEHEM — THE WELL BY THE GATE — DAY

Women at the well with their jars, in the shade of the town wall.

Two travelers come up the road: an older woman, a younger one with an accent nobody here has heard yet and cloth bound around her arms.

One of the women at the well straightens up, and stares. NAOMI'S FRIEND (48), twelve years older.

NAOMI'S FRIEND

Naomi?

The other women look up. It goes around the well like wind through barley.

WOMEN AT THE WELL

(overlapping)

Naomi? It's Naomi. Elimelech's Naomi...

The friend comes toward her with her arms out.

Naomi stops her. Not with her hands. With her voice.

NAOMI

Don't call me that.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Don't call me sweet. Call me Mara, because the Almighty has made my life very bitter.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

I went away full, and the Lord has brought me back empty.

Beside her, Ruth hears it. Empty. The camera finds her face.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Why call me Naomi, when the Lord has testified against me, and the Almighty has brought this on me?

Silence at the well.

Nobody introduces the foreigner. The women look at her the way the town will look at her for weeks: the accent, the cuts on her arms. The Moabite.

EXT. NAOMI'S HOUSE — DAY

The house Naomi left twelve years ago. The roof has fallen in. Thistles fill the courtyard. A lizard on the warm stones.

Naomi walks into the middle of it and sits down. Just sits.

Ruth sets down the bundles. Looks at the fallen beams. Then she pushes her sleeves up over the bound cuts and starts clearing stones, the way Elimelech once cleared a ruin in Moab.

EXT. BOAZ'S TERRACES — EVENING

Evening light on ripe barley, terrace after terrace, all the way down the hill.

FADE TO BLACK.

ACT TWO: THE FIELD

FADE IN:

EXT. NAOMI'S HOUSE — DAWN

The ruin, with the sky for a roof. Some of the stones are stacked against the wall now.

Ruth is already up, retying the cloth on her arms. Naomi lies on her mat with her face to the wall.

RUTH

Let me go out to the fields and
glean behind anyone who'll let me.

A long pause.

NAOMI

Go, my daughter.

EXT. BARLEY FIELDS BELOW BETHLEHEM — MORNING

The whole valley at work. REAPERS, young men, cut the barley in handfuls with sickles. YOUNG WOMEN bind the sheaves behind them. And behind them come the GLEANERS, bent double, picking up what falls: widows, orphans, the poorest people in town.

Ruth walks the field edges, looking for a place. One field. Then another.

At a boundary stone she stops, for no reason we can see.

A young FOREMAN (about 25) is walking the line with a stick.

RUTH

Can I glean here? Among the sheaves,
behind the reapers?

FOREMAN

Behind the reapers, like everyone
else. The sheaves are the master's
business.

She nods, and goes to the back of the line.

EXT. BOAZ'S FIELD — MORNING

The work is brutal. Sun. Dust. Stubble that cuts through
sandals.

The other gleaners don't make room for her. When she bends
for a stalk, someone else's hand is already there.

A YOUNG REAPER flicks a stalk at her head. She doesn't
react.

Later, a BIG REAPER walking past knocks her basket over
with his foot. The young men laugh.

Ruth kneels and picks up every grain. Every single one.

Two gleaners work near her: a YOUNG GLEANER (20s),
sharp-tongued, and an OLD GLEANER (60s), who never stops
working.

YOUNG GLEANER

(loud enough)

A Moabite, gleaning in Bethlehem.
Let her glean in Moab.

OLD GLEANER

(without looking up)

You're in Boaz's field. He's a man
of worth.

OLD GLEANER (CONT'D)

And his own family comes from Rahab.

YOUNG GLEANER

Rahab the prostitute?

OLD GLEANER

Rahab of Jericho. And you're eating
her family's barley, so mind your
mouth.

Ruth keeps her head down. She's heard all of it.

EXT. BOAZ'S FIELD — LATER

A man comes down the path from town: BOAZ (45). There's grey in his beard now, and nobody walks behind him.

BOAZ
(calling out to the field)
The Lord be with you!

REAPERS
(calling back)
The Lord bless you!

He looks out over his field, and sees her at once: a stranger at the back of the gleaners.

BOAZ
(to the foreman)
Whose girl is that?

FOREMAN
(careful, a little defensive)
She's the Moabite girl, the one who came back with Naomi from Moab.

FOREMAN (CONT'D)
She's been on her feet since morning. Hardly sat down in the shelter.

Boaz looks at her for a long moment. Naomi. Moab.

EXT. BOAZ'S FIELD — CONTINUOUS

Boaz walks out through the stubble to Ruth. The gleaners near her go very still.

BOAZ
Don't go and glean in anyone else's field. Don't leave this one. Stay close to my young women.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
Keep your eyes on the field they're reaping, and follow them. I've told the young men not to touch you.

He glances at the big reaper. The big reaper finds something interesting to look at in the barley.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
When you're thirsty, go to the jars and drink what the young men have drawn.

Ruth goes down on her face in the stubble, forehead to the ground.

RUTH

Why would you notice me? I'm a foreigner.

BOAZ

I've heard what you've done for your mother-in-law since your husband died.

BOAZ (CONT'D)

How you left your father and your mother and the land you were born in, and came to a people you didn't know.

BOAZ (CONT'D)

May the Lord repay you for it. May you be paid in full by the Lord, the God of Israel, under whose wings you've come to take shelter.

RUTH

You comfort me. You speak to my heart, and I'm not even one of your servants.

EXT. BOAZ'S FIELD — THE SHELTER — MIDDAY

A shade of branches on poles at the edge of the field. The workers eat: bread, a bowl of sour wine for dipping, roasted grain in a pan over a small fire.

Ruth sits apart, at the end of the reapers.

BOAZ

Come over here. Have some bread, and dip it in the wine.

She comes. The reapers shift to make room, because he's watching. She dips her bread.

Boaz takes a handful of roasted grain from the pan and holds it out to her himself, in front of everyone.

She eats until she's full.

Then she folds what's left into her shawl.

When she goes back to work, Boaz speaks to his young men, quietly.

BOAZ

Let her glean even among the
sheaves, and don't shame her.

BOAZ (CONT'D)

Pull some stalks out of the bundles
and leave them for her to pick up.
Don't scold her.

He looks at the big reaper.

BOAZ (CONT'D)

You.

The big reaper's face falls.

EXT. BOAZ'S FIELD — AFTERNOON

The big reaper, sullen, pulls stalks out of a sheaf and
drops them in Ruth's path, one at a time.

She looks at the stalks. At him. He doesn't look back.

She picks them up.

EXT. EDGE OF BOAZ'S FIELD — EVENING

Ruth beats out her gleanings with a stick on a flat rock.
The barley comes loose and runs into a pile.

It's a big pile. It fills her shawl and then some: a load
that bends her back.

EXT. BETHLEHEM — STREET — DUSK

She carries it home through town. People turn to watch her
go by: the Moabite, with a sack of barley the size of a
child on her back.

EXT. NAOMI'S HOUSE — DUSK

The courtyard is half cleared: stones stacked, thistles
gone. Still no roof.

Naomi sits where she's sat all day. She looks up at the
sound of the gate.

Ruth lets the load down onto the ground. It lands heavily.

Naomi looks at it.

Then she gets to her feet.

NAOMI

Where did you glean today? Where did
you work?

She opens the sack. Puts her hand into the grain, all the way to the wrist.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Blessed is the man who noticed you!

Ruth unties her shawl and holds out what she saved from lunch. Naomi takes the roasted grain, and eats.

RUTH

The man I worked with today... his name is Boaz.

Something wakes up in Naomi's face.

NAOMI

Boaz.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

He gave us his own barley, the day we left.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

The Lord bless him! He hasn't stopped being kind, to the living or the dead!

NAOMI (CONT'D)

That man is family.

RUTH

(looking up)

Family?

NAOMI

One of our redeemers.

Ruth doesn't know the word. Naomi sees that, and explains it the way you would to a foreigner.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

When a family loses something, its land, or a man's freedom, the family has the right to buy it back. Whoever buys it back is the redeemer.

Ruth takes that in. Then she warms up.

RUTH

He even told me to stay close to his young men until they've finished the whole harvest.

NAOMI

(drily)

His young women, my daughter.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Better that you go out with his
women, so no one bothers you in
somebody else's field.

It's the first joke Naomi's made since Moab. Ruth almost
smiles.

EXT. BOAZ'S FIELD — THE SHELTER — MIDDAY

This time we stay with Boaz.

At the midday meal he takes up a handful of roasted grain
from the pan and starts across the field toward Ruth with
it.

Halfway there, he stops.

One of the young reapers has said something that makes her
laugh, and the young men around her are laughing too:
young, quick, loud.

Boaz looks at them. Then at the grain in his hand.

He turns back, and holds it out to the foreman.

BOAZ

Take her this.

FOREMAN

You could take it yourself.

Boaz looks at the young men again.

BOAZ

Take it.

INT. BOAZ'S HOUSE — NIGHT

A good house, and too quiet. Boaz eats alone by one lamp.

In the corner stands a water jar: the one his wife carried
down the terraces in the famine. It's dry. Nobody has
moved it.

EXT. BOAZ'S FIELD — DAY

The last of the wheat. Ruth binds sheaves among Boaz's
young women now.

Toward the end of the day, the young women start a harvest
song. Ruth knows it, and sings it with them: the song
Naomi taught her in Moab. She gets every word right.

YOUNG WOMEN
 (singing)
 ...a month for the harvest and
 measuring...

The young women look at her differently after that. The one binding beside her, a YOUNG WOMAN (17), keeps glancing over.

YOUNG WOMAN
 Where did you learn that?

RUTH
 Moab.

The young woman laughs, surprised. Then, lower, with a look across the field:

YOUNG WOMAN
 He's been alone since the famine
 took his wife.

Ruth follows her look. Boaz, at the edge of the field, watching her.

When she looks up, he looks away.

The cuts on Ruth's arms have healed pale.

INT. NAOMI'S HOUSE — NIGHT

The house has a roof again: new beams, branches, packed mud. Along the wall, jars full of grain. A pot on the fire, and Naomi at it, cooking.

Ruth has fallen asleep by the lamp, worn out.

Naomi watches her for a long time.

Then her eyes go to the little flask of oil on the shelf.

FADE TO BLACK.

ACT THREE: THE THRESHING FLOOR

FADE IN:

INT. NAOMI'S HOUSE — DAY

Naomi sits down across from Ruth. Deliberately, the way she once sat down across from Ruth's father.

NAOMI
 Ruth.

Ruth looks up. Twelve years, and Naomi has never once called her by her name.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Isn't it time I found you a place to rest, where things will go well for you?

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Boaz is family. You've been with his young women all harvest.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Tonight he's winnowing barley on the threshing floor.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

So wash. Put on oil. Put on your cloak, and go down to the floor.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Don't let him see you until he's finished eating and drinking. When he lies down, notice where.

NAOMI (CONT'D)

Then go in, uncover his feet, and lie down. He'll tell you what to do.

Ruth looks at her for a long time.

RUTH

I'll do everything you say.

INT. NAOMI'S HOUSE — EVENING

Water in a basin. Ruth washes.

She takes off the widow's clothes she's worn since Moab, and folds them.

She rubs oil into her arms, over the pale scars.

Naomi combs out Ruth's hair. Her hands are shaking.

Ruth reaches up and puts her hand over Naomi's.

Naomi's hands go still. She finishes the braid.

EXT. THRESHING FLOOR — RIDGE EAST OF BETHLEHEM — SUNSET

The floor from the first shot of the prologue. Now it's heaped with grain.

Men toss forkfuls into the evening breeze off the sea. The chaff streams away gold, and the grain falls back heavy.

Boaz eats and drinks with his workers by firelight. He laughs at something. His heart is content.

When the work's done, the men lie down to sleep around the floor in their cloaks, to guard the grain. Boaz lies down at the far end of the grain heap.

EXT. BELOW THE THRESHING FLOOR — NIGHT

Ruth waits in the dark among the rocks below the floor, wrapped in her cloak. Moonlight. Snoring.

A WORKER gets up and walks a few paces toward where she's hiding.

She stops breathing.

He relieves himself against a rock, and goes back to his cloak.

She waits longer.

Then she goes up. Barefoot. Quiet. Past the sleeping men, to the far end of the grain heap.

She kneels at his feet. She lifts the edge of his cloak off them, and folds it back.

She lies down.

EXT. THRESHING FLOOR — MIDNIGHT

Cold. Boaz shivers in his sleep and reaches down for the cloak that isn't covering his feet.

He jerks up and twists around. There's a shape at his feet. A woman.

BOAZ
(a whisper)
Who are you?

RUTH
I'm Ruth, your servant.

RUTH (CONT'D)
Spread your wing over your servant.
You're a redeemer.

Naomi told her he'd tell her what to do. Instead, she's telling him. And she's tied her own marriage to the rescue of Naomi's family.

They're very close. The dark, the cold, her breath, the scent of the oil.

A long moment.

BOAZ
The Lord bless you, my daughter.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
This kindness is even greater than
the first. You haven't gone after
the young men, poor or rich.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
Now don't be afraid. I'll do
everything you ask. The whole town
knows you're a woman of worth.

His hand goes to the corner of his cloak, the wing, and
stops there.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
It's true that I'm a redeemer. But
there's one closer than I am.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
Stay here tonight. In the morning,
if he'll redeem you, good. Let him.
And if he won't...

He looks at her.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
...then as Yahweh lives, I'll redeem
you myself.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
Lie down until morning.

EXT. THRESHING FLOOR — NIGHT

They lie awake the rest of the night, an arm's length
apart, under the stars, in the wind.

His cloak stays where it is. Until the morning settles who
has the right, it isn't his to spread.

EXT. THRESHING FLOOR — BEFORE DAWN

Grey. Too dark to see a face.

Boaz gets up. Low:

BOAZ
No one can know a woman came to the
floor.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
Hold out your shawl.

She does. He pours barley into it, measure after measure,
six of them, until it's heavy. He ties it, and lifts it
onto her back.

Then he goes up toward the town.

INT. NAOMI'S HOUSE — DAWN

Naomi at the door. She hasn't slept.

NAOMI
How did it go, my daughter?

Ruth sets down the barley and tells her everything.

RUTH
He gave me these six measures of
barley. He said I shouldn't come
back to you empty.

Empty. Naomi's own word, from the day she came home.

Naomi has to sit down.

NAOMI
Wait, my daughter, until you see how
it plays out.

NAOMI (CONT'D)
The man won't rest until he's
settled it.

ACT FOUR: THE GATE

FADE IN:

EXT. BETHLEHEM — THE GATE — MORNING

The gate from the prologue. Boaz comes up through it and sits down on the elders' bench, where Elimelech sold the use of his field twelve years ago.

Already on the bench: THE OLD ELDER (80s), the same dry stick of a man, older still.

Along the street comes a solid, careful man in his fifties: MR. SO-AND-SO. His SON (12) walks at his elbow, to learn how business is done at the gate.

Boaz calls out to him by name. A DONKEY tethered by the gate brays right over it, long and loud, and the name is lost.

BOAZ
Come over here and sit down.

The man comes over and sits. His son stands behind him.

Boaz looks along the gate and picks out ten of the elders.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
Sit down here.

They sit. A crowd gathers, the way it does at the gate.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
Naomi, who's come back from Moab, is
selling the piece of land that
belonged to our brother Elimelech.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
I thought I should tell you. Buy it,
in front of the people sitting here
and the elders of my people.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
If you'll redeem it, redeem it. If
you won't, tell me, so I know.
There's nobody before you to redeem
it, and I'm next.

The man brightens. Land is land.

MR. SO-AND-SO
I'll redeem it.

BOAZ
On the day you buy the field from
Naomi, you also acquire Ruth the
Moabite, the dead man's wife, to
keep the dead man's name alive on
his land.

"Moabite" lands on the crowd like a stone. A murmur goes
along the benches.

The man's face does the arithmetic: the price, a field
that will pass to a son who counts as Mahlon's, two more
mouths.

MR. SO-AND-SO
Then I can't redeem it.

His eyes go to the boy at his elbow, and stay there.

MR. SO-AND-SO (CONT'D)
I'd be ruining my own inheritance.

MR. SO-AND-SO (CONT'D)
(to Boaz)
You take my right. I can't do it.

He reaches down and pulls off his sandal.

HIS SON
(low)
Why your sandal?

MR. SO-AND-SO
(low, not unkindly)
Land is yours where your foot walks.
I'm giving him my walking.

He holds it out to Boaz.

MR. SO-AND-SO (CONT'D)
Buy it yourself.

Boaz takes the sandal.

He stands, and speaks to the elders and all the people.

BOAZ
You are witnesses today.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
I've bought from Naomi everything
that belonged to Elimelech, and
everything that belonged to Chilion
and Mahlon.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
And I've acquired Ruth the Moabite,
Mahlon's wife, as my wife, to keep
the dead man's name alive on his
land, so that his name isn't cut off
from his family, or from the gate of
his town.

He has no son of his own, and he's just agreed that his
first son will carry another man's name. That's the price
the nearer redeemer wouldn't pay.

BOAZ (CONT'D)
You are witnesses today.

The old elder gets to his feet first.

THE OLD ELDER
We are witnesses.

ALL AT THE GATE
We are witnesses!

THE OLD ELDER
May the Lord make the woman who's
coming into your house like Rachel
and Leah, the two who built the
house of Israel.

AN ELDER
May you do worthily in Ephrathah,
and make a name in Bethlehem.

ANOTHER ELDER

And may your house be like the house
of Perez, whom Tamar bore to Judah,
through the children the Lord gives
you by this young woman.

The old elder looks at Boaz, and at the sandal in his hand, and nods slowly, like a man crossing off an old account.

INT. NAOMI'S HOUSE — SAME MORNING

Ruth can't sit still. She's up, she's down, she's at the door again.

Naomi grinds grain on the quern without looking up. Too hard.

A shadow fills the doorway.

Boaz, with a sandal in his hand.

He doesn't say anything. He looks at Naomi. Then at Ruth.

Naomi stops grinding.

EXT. BETHLEHEM — NIGHT

Music: drums, lyres, pipes. Torches, a feast, all of Bethlehem.

At the center of it, Boaz spreads the corner of his cloak over Ruth.

At the edge of the dancing, Naomi watches.

Her old friend comes and takes both her hands, and pulls.

For a moment Naomi resists. Then she goes. She dances, the way she danced at her sons' weddings in Moab.

Later: a closed door, and the lamp behind it going out.

INT. BOAZ'S HOUSE — DAY

Ruth by the doorway, spinning wool. The water jar in the corner is full.

Naomi crosses the room and puts her hand on Ruth's belly. She keeps it there.

We see Naomi's face.

INT. BOAZ'S HOUSE — NIGHT

The birthing stones. Lamps. MIDWIVES, and the WOMEN OF BETHLEHEM crowded in, Naomi's friend among them.

Ruth on the stones, in labor. Naomi behind her, gripping both her hands.

It's long, and it's dangerous. Ruth screams.

MIDWIFE

Now. Push now.

Outside, Boaz stands against the wall by the door. He hasn't moved for hours.

Then a cry. A baby's cry.

Boaz closes his eyes.

INT. BOAZ'S HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

The baby on Ruth's chest, wet and furious. Ruth is laughing and crying at once.

The women turn to Naomi.

NAOMI'S FRIEND

Blessed be the Lord, who hasn't left you without a redeemer today!

A WOMAN

May his name be famous in Israel.

ANOTHER WOMAN

He'll bring your life back. He'll take care of you when you're old.

NAOMI'S FRIEND

Because your daughter-in-law who loves you, who's better to you than seven sons, has given birth to him.

Better than seven sons. Ruth hears it the way she heard "empty" at the well.

Naomi looks at Ruth for a long moment. And this time she sees her.

Ruth holds out the baby. Naomi takes him, and lays him in her lap.

Naomi's friend looks right at her, and says the name on purpose.

NAOMI'S FRIEND

A son has been born to Naomi!

The name she refused at the well. This time she doesn't refuse it.

Naomi laughs. Really laughs, for the first time since her sons died. The women laugh with her.

NAOMI'S FRIEND

Obed.

WOMEN OF BETHLEHEM

(taking it up)

Obed. Obed!

EXT. NAOMI'S HOUSE — ROOF — DUSK

The roof Ruth put back on the ruin.

Naomi sits on it with Obed in her arms. She looks east, across the rift, to where the mountains of Moab are turning blue. Her husband and her sons are buried over there.

She sings to the baby, softly: the lullaby she hummed at Mahlon's bedside. This time, with the words.

Below her, the barley is ripening on Boaz's terraces.

The wind comes up off the desert.

The camera comes down from the mountains to the child in her arms, and rests on Obed's face.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END